

Comparing Three-Digit Numbers

Answer Key

Grade 2–3 Mathematics

Quick Answers

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|----------------|------------------|------------------|
| 1. — | 5. 437, 473, 743 | 9. 650, 605, 560 |
| 2. 352, 328, — | 6. 209, 198, — | 10. 557, —, — |
| 3. — | 7. — | |
| 4. — | 8. — | |
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Curriculum

Level: Grade 2–3 Mathematics

2.NBT.A – problems 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10

Difficulty 1–5 of 5 across 16 tagged checks.

Common wrong answers

6. If they got 29: skipped the empty tens place and wrote the hundreds digit next to the ones digit

1. Red bin 462 books, blue bin 429 books.

Chart both numbers, then read from the left.

Hundreds: 4 and 4 — the same, so the hundreds place decides nothing.

Tens: 6 and 2. Six tens is more than two tens, so the red bin wins here and the ones digits never have to be looked at.

$$\boxed{462 > 429}$$

2. Ella: 3 flats, 5 rods, 2 cubes. Ryan: 3 flats, 2 rods, 8 cubes.

Each flat is one hundred, each rod is one ten, each cube is one.

Ella: $3 \times 100 + 5 \times 10 + 2 = 300 + 50 + 2$, so $\boxed{352}$ Ryan: $3 \times 100 + 2 \times 10 + 8 = 300 + 20 + 8$, so $\boxed{328}$

Same hundreds (3 each), so compare tens: 5 rods beats 2 rods.

$$\boxed{352 > 328}$$

Grading note: Ryan has more cubes, so a student who compares ones first will pick Ryan. Comparing always starts at the left.

3. Compare 508 and 580.

Hundreds: 5 and 5 — tied.

Tens: 0 and 8. Zero tens is fewer than eight tens, so 508 is the smaller number. The **tens place** is the place that decides this pair.

$$508 < 580$$

Grading note: the 0 is not "nothing there" — it holds the tens place open so the 8 stays in the ones place.

4. Oak 615 cans, Pine 651 cans.

Hundreds: 6 and 6 — tied. Tens: 1 and 5, so Pine has more tens.

$$615 < 651$$

Pine School collected more cans.

5. Order 473, 437, 743 from least to greatest.

Compare hundreds first: 4, 4, and 7. The 7 hundreds is the biggest, so 743 goes last no matter what.

The two numbers with 4 hundreds are separated by their tens: 7 tens against 3 tens, so 437 comes before 473.

$$437, 473, 743$$

6. Sam: 2 flats, 0 rods, 9 cubes. Nina: 1 flat, 9 rods, 8 cubes.

Sam: $2 \times 100 + 0 \times 10 + 9 = 200 + 0 + 9$, so $\boxed{209}$

Nina: $1 \times 100 + 9 \times 10 + 8 = 100 + 90 + 8$, so $\boxed{198}$

Nina really does have more rods, but rods are only tens. Sam has 2 hundreds against Nina's 1 hundred, and hundreds are compared first, so Sam's number is greater.

$$209 > 198$$

Grading note: 29 means the empty tens place was skipped when writing Sam's number — the 0 has to be written so the 9 stays in the ones place.

7. Compare 384 and 389.

Hundreds tie at 3. Tens tie at 8. So the ones place is the only place left, and 4 is less than 9.

$$384 < 389$$

8. Maya 892 steps, Ben 928 steps.

Maya is looking at the wrong place. Comparing starts at the hundreds: 8 hundreds against 9 hundreds. Ben has more hundreds, so Ben's number is greater and the tens digits are never needed.

$$892 < 928$$

Ben walked more steps. Maya is not right.

9. Order 605, 650, 560 from greatest to least.

Hundreds: 6, 6, and 5. The number with 5 hundreds, 560, is the smallest, so it goes last.

The two numbers with 6 hundreds split on their tens: 0 tens against 5 tens, so 650 is greater than 605.

$$650, 605, 560$$

10. Challenge: 5 hundreds, missing tens, 7 ones.

Try the tens digits in order. The hundreds and ones already match 547, so the tens digit is what settles both tests.

A tens digit of 4 gives 547, which is equal to 547 and not greater than it. The next digit up is 5, giving $\boxed{557}$

Check the first test — same hundreds, and 5 tens beats 4 tens:

$$\boxed{557 > 547}$$

Check the second test — same hundreds, and 5 tens is fewer than 8 tens:

$$\boxed{557 < 587}$$

So the smallest number that passes both tests is 557; any tens digit from 5 to 7 works, but 5 is the smallest of them.